

33. Truganini, the last native Tasmanian.

Portrait: C. A. Woolley, 1866, National Library of Australia (ref: an23378504).

Why Europe?

The fact that people from a large island in the northern Atlantic conquered a large island south of Australia is one of history's more bizarre occurrences. Not long before Cook's expedition, the British Isles and western Europe in general were but distant backwaters of the Mediterranean world. Little of importance ever happened there. Even the Roman Empire – the only important premodern European empire – derived most of its wealth from its North African, Balkan and Middle Eastern provinces. Rome's western